

Does ‘Ought’ Imply ‘Can’ (OiC) in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (NE)?

(1) ‘deliberatively ought’ conceptually implies ‘can’ within the scope of deliberation; (2) there’s good reason to think ‘ought’ conceptually implies ‘can’ within the scope of activities; (3) Aristotle is sensitive to the demandingness considerations that underwrite OiC; (4) particular cases of OiC might merit weaker readings of ‘imply’ like pragmatic implication or presupposition; (5) the incurably vicious person is not an example of someone who ought to do what she is unable; (6) the concept ‘wish’ explains the grip of the good things not up to us.

Contrapositive: ‘cannot’ implies it’s not possible that ‘ought’

Standard (Kantian): ‘ought’ implies ‘can’

Presupposition: ‘cannot’ implies there’s no *point* in saying ‘ought’

1. It is safe to reconstruct a ‘deliberatively ought’ which conceptually implies ‘can’ for the prescriptions of deliberation (correct reason in accord with correct desire), since the proper objects of deliberation are only those things doable in action.

[T1] And nobody deliberates about what cannot be otherwise, or about such things as have no end at all that is a good doable in action. The unconditionally good deliberator, however, is the one capable of aiming at and hitting, in accord with rational calculation, the best for a human being of things doable in action (NE VI.7, 1141b8-12).

2. There is good reason to think that ‘ought’ implies ‘can’ more generally for activities which are not primarily construed as actions (external movements of the body brought about by an internal cause).

[T2] One must not, in accord with the makers of proverbs, “think human things, since you are human” or “think mortal things, since you are mortal,” but rather one must as far as possible immortalize and do everything to live in accord with the element in oneself that is most excellent (NE X.7, 1177b30-1178a1).

3. Aristotle is sensitive to the demandingness considerations underwriting weakened versions of OiC: the poor can be generous and the scientifically ignorant practically wise.

[T3] Nothing prevents a person who gives less from being more generous, then, if he has less from which to give (NE IV.1, 1120b5-10).

[T4] For ignorance in our deliberate choice is not a cause of something's being involuntary but of depravity, [...] but ignorance of the particulars in which the action lies and with which it is concerned [...] for it is the person who is ignorant of one of these particulars who acts involuntarily (NE III.1, 1110b-1111a1).

4. It's not clear how strong a reading some instantiations of the principle merit. (1) & (2) suggest an inference rule, but some cases may only exhibit presupposition.

[T5] If the recipient can, then, he must make a return of equal worth to what he has received and do so voluntarily (for he must not make the other party an involuntary friend). [...] But if he is unable, not even the giver would claim he deserves it. So if it is possible, he must repay (NE VIII.13, 1163a1-8).

5. It is difficult to make sense of the incurably vicious person with respect to (1) & (2). She is blameworthy for her vicious actions. Intuitively you ought not do what it would be blameworthy to do. But she is unable to do otherwise. Therefore she ought to do what she is unable to do. 'Ought' doesn't imply 'can'.

[T6] But if someone non-ignorantly does the actions that would result in his being unjust, he will be voluntarily unjust. This does not mean that if he wishes, he will stop being unjust and will be just instead. For the diseased person will not be healthy that way either, even if, as it happens, he is diseased voluntarily because of living a life that lacks self-control and disobeying his doctors. At one time, certainly, it was possible for him not to be sick. Once he has let himself go, however, it is no longer possible, just as when someone has let a stone go it is no longer possible for him to get it back. Nonetheless, throwing it was up to him; for the starting-point was in him. In the same way, it was possible at the start for the unjust and the intemperate person not to become like that, which is why such people are voluntarily unjust and intemperate. But once they have become like that, it is no longer possible not to be (NE III.5, 1114a10-25).

NB: Recall that our *moral* intuitions may be confounding here (Anscombe 1958).

6. The concept 'wish' can satisfy nagging worries that what is choiceworthy, or noble, or pleasurable, or useful, etc, really does generate an 'ought' in one sense or another even when having the object of wish isn't up to us.

[T7] [...] there is no deliberate choice of impossible things, and if someone were to say he was deliberately choosing them, he would seem silly. But there is wish for impossible things—for example, immortality (NE III.2, 1111b-1111a).

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